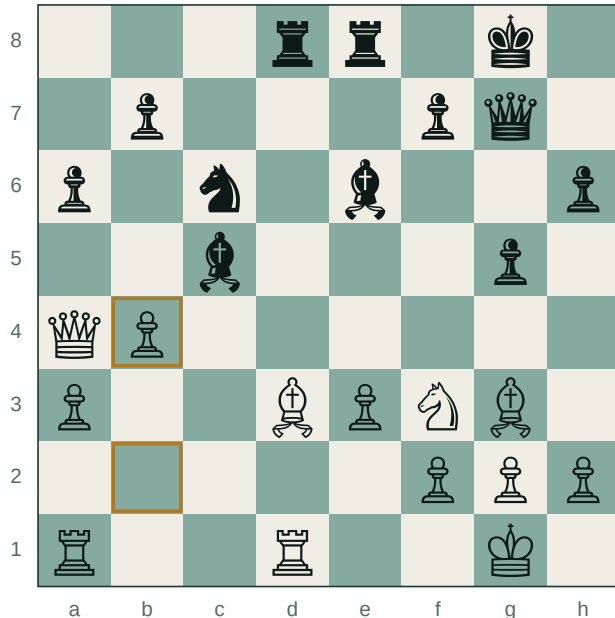


Deflection tactics: Black, move 20

Deflection tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 20.b4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20...Rxd3 21. Rxd3 Qxa1+

20...Rxd3 The rook captures the bishop on d3. Recorded reply: **21.Rxd3**.

21...Qxa1+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on a1.

At the end, nominal material is White 26 / Black 28 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A replacement defender or an intermediate check can keep the target safe even after the original defender moves.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Deflection distracts a defender from a critical job. Its new square matters less than the fact that it no longer guards the original target.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the defender's job, find a forcing way to divert it, and calculate the move that exploits the abandoned square.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on a4. Check for tactical protection.